

Vertu's Back!

Luxury product makers Vertu have launched a couple of variants for its 'Ascent' range of cell phones. The Vertu Ascent Motorsport will be available in October while the new Ascent White Special edition will be revealed soon. Expect to pay through your nose for it, since only 997 units will be sold.



Future of IE 7

It doesn't look like there would be anything new about IE 7 till later this year. But there would be a refresh of the "standalone" Internet Explorer 7 Beta 1. The build will be released before Beta 2 of IE 7 is shipped. Here's what we think: December for Beta 2 for both Windows Vista and Internet Explorer 7.



Enter

Alisha Chinai Singer

Alisha Chinai is India's first pop diva. Here, the glamorous 'Made In India' star speaks on gadgets, gizmos and tech in general.

What does technology mean to you?

For me, technology means progress, innovation and new ideas. However, I am still conservative when it comes to using gadgets.

How do you use technology in your daily life?

I answer e-mails on a daily basis. I find tools such as SMSes very impersonal. I invariably avoid text messaging if I can call. Anyway, overdependence on anything is not normal; and technology is no exception.

What gadgets do you own?

I have a no-frills mobile phone which I use to primarily make or receive calls. I have a computer at my office. I do own the normal consumer electronics including a DVD player, TV set and a music player. Of the new gizmos available, I would like to own an iPod which I think is quite cool.

Has technology helped you professionally?

Technology has given us various tools that help voice artists. At the same time, it also makes mediocre voices sound exceptional, which I consider to be a flipside. Tools such as pitch correctors have given music an extremely synthesised feel today. Although it hasn't influenced my career in any direct manner, technology has definitely made a lot of processes in my work easier.

REALITY BITES

Blogs, Online Communities Rush To Help

In the last 20 years or so, the US has been associated with many catastrophes. Some caused by them, some unto them. The latest is hurricane Katrina, which has left the city of New Orleans almost unrecognisable. But this time, there is a difference in the way Americans (and the world) knew of the details and how they responded to the tragedy.

Blogs have once again come to the fore in times of need. After last year's tsunami, when multiple blogs helped network the world and bring in aid, this is the second instance of blogging coming to the forefront and aiming to help out people.

All across the Web, blogs and Web sites have assisted with the relief and aid mobilisation. Right from the blog by Michael Barnett (The Interdictor) and his LiveJournal to the Times-Picayune Breaking News Blog, Web surfers around the world have access to unfiltered information coming out of New Orleans. Web sites such as the Katrina Information Map and even television stations are using Google Earth to provide status updates of specific locations affected by the hurricane and its aftermath.

An interesting development has been the acceptance of 'tech-in-kind' donations by the Red Cross. Technology companies hurried to do their bit to enable better communications between public safety officials and

left behind. A Katrina Help Wiki that was set up soon after the disaster struck was helped further with Skype entering the picture. In conjunction with Skype, SkypeJournal and Khaos Labs, they set up a

messaging centre using Skype and its API, reported Dina Mehta - who was at the forefront of this development - on her blog.

But all was not rosy in terms of the relief efforts. PayPal had to block some relief funds raised by humour site Something Awful. The site had raised almost \$28,000 (Rs 12,60,000) in less than nine hours until PayPal froze

the funds. Why? Because PayPal's customer support was closed for the night. As a result, founder of the Something Awful site, Rich Kyanka, was unable to discover why \$27,695.41 in Red Cross relief funds was locked. PayPal's automated system explained that it had received more than one report of suspicious behaviour from his buyers.

A furious Kyanka was then asked by a PayPal service executive to fax in a driver's license, bank records, credit card records, and a written request to



Illustrations Harsho Mohan Chatteraj

rescue workers, but Netizens the world over are eager to offer assistance as well. With the volume of information about and for Katrina victims increasing on the Web, a call has already gone out for ways to manage the information flow.

Leading the way in this has been Microsoft with its .NET framework. It developed a system to help locate people displaced or missing since the hurricane through KatrinaSafe (www.katrinasafer.com).

Indian bloggers were not

